resources: self-help manuals). He cut his links with the community into which he was born (he was actually expelled from his caste group for having polluted himself by travelling overseas), and found ways to create for himself communities of choice, drawn from all religions. These communities included his fellow workers in South Africa, the motley individuals he assembled in the ashrams that he established, and most importantly, the Congress movement – which he hoped could stand for his vision of an Indian nation undivided by religion or caste.

In the sphere of religion and God, Gandhi writes of how, by opening himself up to the competing claims of Christianity, Hinduism, and Islam, he experienced a 'mental churning', which led him to a spiritual crisis. 'I do not know where I am, and what is and what should be my belief', he recalls telling one religious interlocutor. His search led him in and out of spiritual 'Seeker's Clubs', and finally towards a desire for a direct and personal relation to God, unmediated by tradition or priests, and not bound by the dogma of any one religious faith. He had to face directly, in his spiritual commitments as in his daily practice, the question of choice. His vegetarianism, for instance, was the product of an active and reasoned choice and one made, as he insisted, 'independently of religious texts'. So, too, in his religious philosophy, the necessity of choice led him to create a unique religious blend that drew upon legends and stories from India's popular religious traditions, and wove these together with strands of Christian teaching. 'Saints and seers', he wrote, 'have left their experiences for us, but they have given us no infallible and